ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

# Subjunctive and formulaic clauses

Use the mandative subjunctive and fixed irrealis forms after recommendations, demands and formal expressions. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use subjunctive and formulaic clauses to state required or recommended action without tense marking inside the subordinate clause while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use the mandative subjunctive and fixed irrealis forms after recommendations, demands and formal expressions.

MODEL

The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered.

recommend/essential + that + subject + base verb

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

## LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main subjunctive and formulaic clauses patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses state required or recommended action without tense marking inside the subordinate clause.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in formal recommendations, policy, legal drafting and institutional english.

# Build meaning before form

Use the mandative subjunctive and fixed irrealis forms after recommendations, demands and formal expressions.

# What subjunctive and formulaic clauses communicates

Use the mandative subjunctive and fixed irrealis forms after recommendations, demands and formal expressions.

The central purpose is to state required or recommended action without tense marking inside the subordinate clause. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

| The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered. | a formal recommendation for an action |
|---|---|
| It is essential that every member remain independent. | a requirement framed as essential |
| The timetable can be revised, if need be. | a conventional formal irrealis expression |

# How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: recommend/essential + that + subject + base verb. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

| Choice | Structure | Example |
|---|---|---|
| Mandative subjunctive | verb + that + subject + base verb | The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered. |
| Adjectival mandate | it is essential + that + subject + base verb | It is essential that every member remain independent. |
| Fixed irrealis | if need be / be that as it may | The timetable can be revised, if need be. |

# Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

| Meaning | Best route |
|---|---|
| a formal recommendation for an action | Mandative subjunctive |
| a requirement framed as essential | Adjectival mandate |
| a conventional formal irrealis expression | Fixed irrealis |

# Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in formal recommendations, policy, legal drafting and institutional english. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

# Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

| 01 | 02 | 03 | 04 |
|---|---|---|---|
| recommend/essential | that | subject | base verb |

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

### Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: state required or recommended action without tense marking inside the subordinate clause.

STEP 2

### Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

### Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

### Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits formal recommendations, policy, legal drafting and institutional english.

STEP 5

### Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

# Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

| Pattern | Form | Model |
|---|---|---|
| Mandative subjunctive | verb + that + subject + base verb | The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered. |
| Adjectival mandate | it is essential + that + subject + base verb | It is essential that every member remain independent. |
| Fixed irrealis | if need be / be that as it may | The timetable can be revised, if need be. |

## EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

| | |
|---|---|
| The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered. | a formal recommendation for an action |
| It is essential that every member remain independent. | a requirement framed as essential |
| The timetable can be revised, if need be. | a conventional formal irrealis expression |

## COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

### Avoid this pattern

Do not add third-person -s or ordinary past tense to the mandative base form.

EDIT THIS

### Avoid this pattern

Do not use remains in the formal subjunctive pattern.

EDIT THIS

### Avoid this pattern

Do not modernise a fixed formula by adding an ordinary finite verb inside it.

# Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a formal recommendation for an action?

OPTIONS The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered. · It is essential that every member remain independent. · The timetable can be revised, if need be.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a requirement framed as essential?

OPTIONS It is essential that every member remain independent. · The timetable can be revised, if need be. · The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a conventional formal irrealis expression?

OPTIONS The timetable can be revised, if need be. · The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered. · It is essential that every member remain independent.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a formal recommendation for an action · a requirement framed as essential · a conventional formal irrealis expression

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “It is essential that every member remain independent.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a requirement framed as essential · a conventional formal irrealis expression · a formal recommendation for an action

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The timetable can be revised, if need be.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a conventional formal irrealis expression · a formal recommendation for an action · a requirement framed as essential

STAGE CHECK

## Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

02 · PRACTICE STAGE

# Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

“The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Mandative subjunctive / Adjectival mandate / Fixed irrealis · Gap 2: a formal recommendation for an action / a requirement framed as essential / a conventional formal irrealis expression

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

“It is essential that every member remain independent.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Adjectival mandate / Fixed irrealis / Mandative subjunctive · Gap 2: a requirement framed as essential / a conventional formal irrealis expression / a formal recommendation for an action

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

“The timetable can be revised, if need be.” uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Fixed irrealis / Mandative subjunctive / Adjectival mandate · Gap 2: a conventional formal irrealis expression / a formal recommendation for an action / a requirement framed as essential

STAGE CHECK

## Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

# Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a formal recommendation for an action: _____. Choose the model that expresses a requirement framed as essential: _____. Choose the model that expresses a conventional formal irrealis expression: _____. Choose the model built with verb + that + subject + base verb: _____. Choose the model built with it is essential + that + subject + base verb: _____. Choose the model built with if need be / be that as it may: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

## Available forms

It is essential that every member remain independent. · The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered. · The timetable can be revised, if need be.

STAGE CHECK

## Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

# Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The panel recommended _____. It is essential _____ independent. The timetable can be revised, _____. State the full structural pattern for Mandative subjunctive: _____. State the full structural pattern for Adjectival mandate: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

## Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

# Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The panel recommended reconsidering the application.” using the Mandative subjunctive pattern to express a formal recommendation for an action.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Every member must remain independent.” using the Adjectival mandate pattern to express a requirement framed as essential.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The timetable can be revised if revision becomes necessary.” using the Fixed irrealis pattern to express a conventional formal irrealis expression.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The panel recommended reconsidering the application.” using the Mandative subjunctive pattern to express a formal recommendation for an action.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

### Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

# Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Mandative subjunctive to express a formal recommendation for an action, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Adjectival mandate to express a requirement framed as essential, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Fixed irrealis to express a conventional formal irrealis expression, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

# Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

# Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered.

Mandative subjunctive is the best match because a formal recommendation for an action.

A2

It is essential that every member remain independent.

Adjectival mandate is the best match because a requirement framed as essential.

A3

The timetable can be revised, if need be.

Fixed irrealis is the best match because a conventional formal irrealis expression.

A4

a formal recommendation for an action

The Mandative subjunctive pattern communicates a formal recommendation for an action.

A5

a requirement framed as essential

The Adjectival mandate pattern communicates a requirement framed as essential.

A6

a conventional formal irrealis expression

The Fixed irrealis pattern communicates a conventional formal irrealis expression.

# Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

### Mandative subjunctive / a formal recommendation for an action

The structure belongs to the Mandative subjunctive pattern. Its communicative purpose is a formal recommendation for an action.

B2

### Adjectival mandate / a requirement framed as essential

The structure belongs to the Adjectival mandate pattern. Its communicative purpose is a requirement framed as essential.

B3

### Fixed irrealis / a conventional formal irrealis expression

The structure belongs to the Fixed irrealis pattern. Its communicative purpose is a conventional formal irrealis expression.

# Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered.

Mandative subjunctive: verb + that + subject + base verb.

C2

It is essential that every member remain independent.

Adjectival mandate: it is essential + that + subject + base verb.

C3

The timetable can be revised, if need be.

Fixed irrealis: if need be / be that as it may.

C4

The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered.

Mandative subjunctive: verb + that + subject + base verb.

C5

It is essential that every member remain independent.

Adjectival mandate: it is essential + that + subject + base verb.

C6

The timetable can be revised, if need be.

Fixed irrealis: if need be / be that as it may.

# Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

that the application be reconsidered

Mandative subjunctive requires “that the application be reconsidered” in this model. verb + that + subject + base verb.

D2

that every member remain

Adjectival mandate requires “that every member remain” in this model. it is essential + that + subject + base verb.

D3

if need be

Fixed irrealis requires “if need be” in this model. if need be / be that as it may.

D4

verb + that + subject + base verb

Mandative subjunctive is built as verb + that + subject + base verb.

D5

it is essential + that + subject + base verb

Adjectival mandate is built as it is essential + that + subject + base verb.

# Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered.

verb + that + subject + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended mandative subjunctive effect.

E2

It is essential that every member remain independent.

it is essential + that + subject + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended adjectival mandate effect.

E3

The timetable can be revised, if need be.

if need be / be that as it may. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended fixed irrealis effect.

E4

The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered.

verb + that + subject + base verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended mandative subjunctive effect.

# Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The panel recommended that the application be reconsidered. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses verb + that + subject + base verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

It is essential that every member remain independent. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses it is essential + that + subject + base verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The timetable can be revised, if need be. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses if need be / be that as it may accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

# Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____